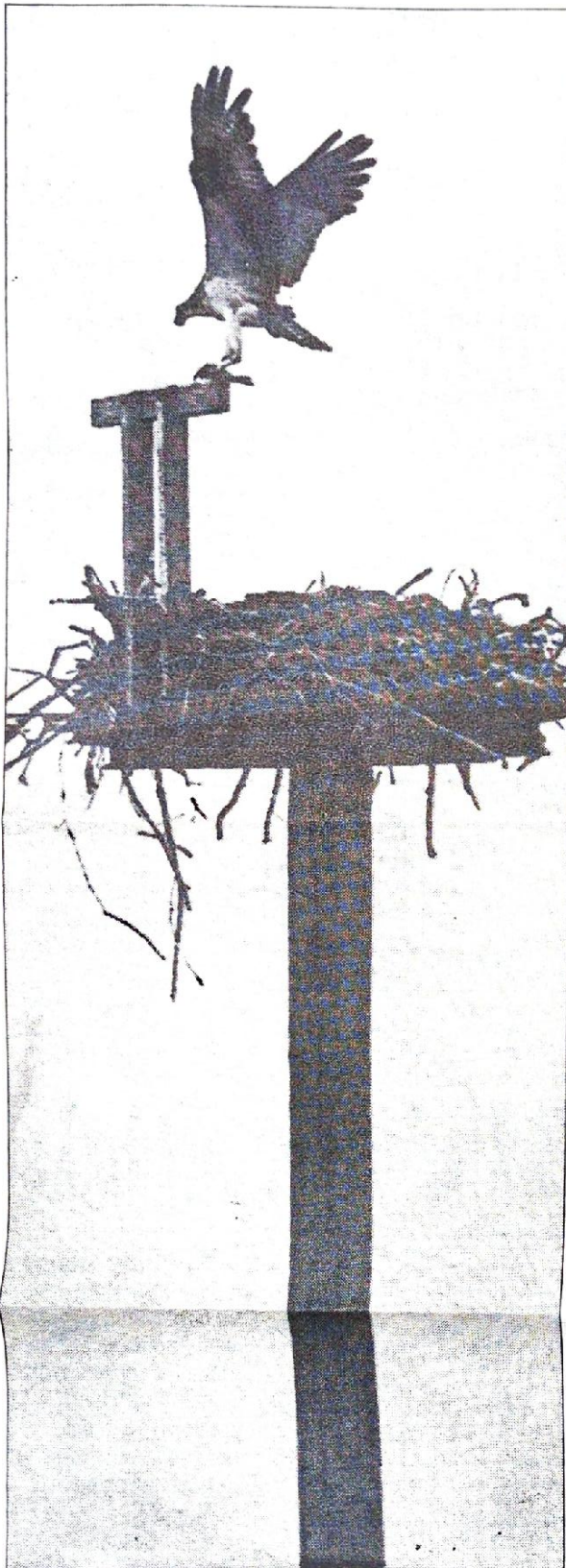


A swoop, a dive, and dinner's served



Take-home dinner: An osprey carries a fish to its nest to share with its mate and offspring at the Energy Explorium.

T. ORTEGA GAINES/Staff

Once-threatened ospreys become a familiar sight at Lake Norman

By PHUONG LY
Staff Writer

LAKE NORMAN — Clutching a fish in his talons, a dark brown bird, white on his belly and crown, circles overhead.

Spreading his wings up to 5 feet, the bird of prey screeches, protective of its territory — an 8-foot-wide nest of sticks, mud and grass perched on a 20-foot-high wooden platform near a deep blue expanse of Lake Norman.

His high-pitched scream is just about the only sound on this humid day.

You would think you were in a secluded wildlife refuge.

Until you look beyond the small roped-off field of dry green and yellow grass. McGuire Nuclear Station, which generates about 20% of the electricity for Duke Power's 1.6 million customers, is only a short walk from the nesting platform. Towers dot the lake area. Power lines criss-cross the horizon. Condominiums crowd the waterfront.

It's a delicate balance of man and nature.

Relocation began years ago

In the past several years, ospreys, often called fish hawks, have become a common sight in the Lake Norman area, according to Iredell County bird-watchers and officials from Duke Power and the Carolina Raptor Center, which monitors raptors, or birds of prey.

"Just about anywhere you go (around Lake Norman), you can see osprey if you stay long enough," said Richard Mize of Barium Springs, a member of an Iredell County bird-watching group. "When they dive and then catch their fish, it's something."

But these birds are more than just a spectacular sight for bird-watchers.

Ospreys in the area also mean a healthy lake environment for man, said Robert Siler, senior scientist for Duke Power Environmental Services.

Nine years ago, scientists and volunteers from Duke Power and the raptor center began relocating baby ospreys from the N.C. coast to Lake Norman to give the birds another home and opportunity to replenish their numbers.

Ospreys, which are native to North America, had been diminished by DDT, a toxic pesticide which was banned in 1972. The pesticide entered the food chain and found its way into fish ospreys depend on. The chemical thinned the shells of the birds' eggs so they broke easily.

'Environmental panic button'

Before the relocation, only a few ospreys had been flying across the man-made lake, on their way to South America for the winter. Since the lake is only 30 years old, it was not a familiar nesting site for ospreys, which return to the same nest every year.

Volunteers hoped that by relocating baby ospreys, the birds would establish nesting areas at Lake Norman, Siler said.

In the five-year relocation program, volunteers nurtured and released about 18 young ospreys. Duke Power and Carolina Raptor Center now only do informal monitoring of ospreys in the area.

Today, about three pairs of ospreys nest in the southern part of Lake Norman, around the nuclear power plant and Cowans Ford Dam. Another pair is making its home near Mountain Island Lake.

About 20 to 30 birds claim the Lake Norman area, said Betty O'Leary, rehabilitation assistant at the Carolina Raptor Center. The birds are also plentiful at the coast now and have been taken off the state's threatened species list.

The success of the relocation program provides Lake Norman with "environmental panic buttons" uniquely sensitive to water, O'Leary said.

If rain washes too many chemicals from suburban

lawns and golf courses or treated wastewater flows into the lake in unhealthy concentrations, the ospreys will be among the first to feel the effects — even if the ospreys are at one end of the lake and the chemical runoff is at the other end.

"If something's going to happen to them, it's going to happen to humans," O'Leary said.

Bird sightings are common

The other raptors in the Lake Norman area — hawks and owls, which feed mainly on rodents — would likely feel the effects of unhealthy chemical runoff more slowly, O'Leary said. "The osprey eat fish, which would have felt all the runoffs from the lake."

Officials at Duke Power State Park in Iredell County often get inquiries from park visitors who have seen the birds. Superintendent Jud Burns said.

"It's nothing special. The birds are known to be in this area," he said. No nests have been found in the 1,458-acre park, though, Burns said.

Joel McConnell of Mooresville sees ospreys when he crosses Lake Norman on I-77.

The hawklike birds are a dark image on the olive-green expanse of lake water and sky. Several hundred yards from the bridge's railing, lone ospreys swoop down close to the water, looking for fish.

"They wander up and down that lake channel," said McConnell, who is a member of the Iredell County bird-watching group. "I love to see them."

Ospreys can be distinguished from other birds by their white undersides, O'Leary said. Their wings show a distinct bend in the "wrist" area, and ospreys are bigger than local hawks.

Even people about 40 miles from the lake report osprey sightings. Lois Goforth of Olin sees ospreys circling around the ponds on her farm several times a year, usually after big storms.

"I almost know when to expect them," said Goforth, who is a member of the Iredell bird-watching group. "I've seen them circling one pond, looking over the situation, staking out an area to feed."

Traffic and people don't bother ospreys much when the birds are hunting, migrating or just flying around, O'Leary said. It's when the environment gets too noisy or crowded that the birds move on. Ospreys also search for secluded areas to nest and breed.

The more secluded spots a lake has, the more ospreys it can support, O'Leary said.

Parks offer nesting sites

Despite shopping centers and subdivisions springing up regularly at Lake Norman, O'Leary said, ospreys will still have a home in the area. They can nest at Latta Plantation Park, a wildlife refuge, and at Duke Power State Park.

For a close look at some of Lake Norman's environmental thermometers, people can take their binoculars and go by boat to the discharge canal at McGuire Nuclear Station. A nesting platform stands a few feet from the edge of the lake. Also, people can go by boat to Cowans Ford Dam, where a pair of ospreys are nesting atop a microwave tower.

Two high wooden platforms where volunteers raised baby ospreys are located on a nature trail near the Duke Power Energy Explorium. There are no birds near this wooded site.

Siler advises bird-watchers not to get too close to the osprey's nesting area.

"He won't attack you, but he'll try to scare you off," Siler said. The almost 2-foot-tall osprey will come a few feet in front of trespassers, spread its 60-inch wingspan and give off a piercing whistle. Repeatedly.

The birds dive head first toward the water. Just before they hit the water, they pivot, slamming the water with their talons and grabbing the unlucky fish.

"You've missed it if you haven't seen them fishing," McConnell said.